

[NT Lesson 4](#): “Prepare Ye the Way of the Lord” (See NTL4 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To inspire us to draw near the Savior by repenting of our sins, keeping our baptismal covenants, and withstanding temptation.

1. John the Baptist prepares the way of the Lord Jesus Christ.

- Read [Matthew 3:1-12](#). †1. Background Information
- [Luke 1:76-79](#) and [3:3-4](#). Mission: “baptism for repentance for the remission of sins”; “guide [to] way of peace”. Why do you think it was important that someone prepare the way of the Lord?
- Matthew 3:1-2. “And saying, Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.”
- What does it mean to repent? (See [2 Cor. 7:9-10](#); [D&C 58:42-43](#); [Luke 19:8](#); [D&C 1:31-32](#); and [Mosiah 7:33](#)).
- [3 Nephi 27:19](#). “nothing entereth into his rest save it be those who have washed their garments in my blood”.
- How does daily repentance, help us draw nearer God and Christ and prepare us to live with them?
- Matthew 3:7-8 and [Luke 7:29-30](#). “Pharisees ... rejected the counsel of God ... being not baptized of [John].”
- †2. The Jews and Baptism
- [Moroni 8: 25-26](#). “And the first fruits of repentance is ...”
- Matthew 3:11. “but he that cometh after ... shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire”. †3. Holy Ghost

2. Jesus is baptized by John the Baptist.

- Read [Matthew 3:13-17](#). “Then cometh Jesus from Galilee to Jordan unto John, to be baptized of him.”
- Why did John hesitate to baptize Jesus? Why did Jesus need to be baptized?
- [2 Nephi 31:6-11](#). “I would ask ... wherein the Lamb of God did fulfill all righteousness in being baptized by water.”
- [2 Nephi 31:5, 12-13, 17-18](#). “12 He that is baptized in my name, to him will the Father give the Holy Ghost, like unto me ... 13 If ye shall follow the Son, with full purpose of heart, acting no hypocrisy and no deception before God, but with real intent, repenting of your sins, witnessing unto the Father that ye are willing to take upon you the name of Christ, by baptism ... then shall ye receive the Holy Ghost”.
- Why do we need to be baptized? †4. Elder Bruce R. McConkie
- [D&C 20:37](#) and [Mosiah 18:8-10](#). These scriptures and our sacramental prayers give us our baptismal covenants.

3. Jesus withstands Satan’s temptations in the wilderness.

- [Matthew 4:1-11](#). See also the Joseph Smith Translation in the footnotes.
- Matthew 4:1 JST. How do fasting, prayer, and being “led ... of the Spirit” bless us and bring us to God?
- Matthew 4:2-3. How does Satan tempt us to give in to physical appetites?
- How can we learn to recognize and resist these temptations?
- Matthew 4:5-6. How does Satan appeal to our pride?
- How can we recognize and withstand temptations to gratify prideful desires?
- Matthew 4:8-9. How does Satan tempt us with worldly riches and power?
- How can we recognize and resist these temptations? †5. President David O. McKay
- What was false about Satan’s offer to give Jesus the kingdoms of the world? (See [D&C 104:14](#).)
- What are some false offers Satan makes today to entice us to sin?
- [Helaman 3:29-30](#). “Jesus responded to each of Satan’s temptations by quoting from the scriptures.”
- How do the scriptures give us strength to withstand temptation? †6. Julie Szejnja’s Testimony
- Why do you think Satan twice questioned whether Jesus was the Son of God? (See Matthew 4:3, 6.)
- How does he raise this question in the world today?
- When facing temptation, how does it help to remember that we are children of God? (See [Moses 1:12-13](#).)
- How does it help to know that Jesus also faced temptations? †7. Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin

4. Some of John the Baptist’s disciples decide to follow Jesus.

- Read [John 1:35-51](#). John said, “Behold the Lamb of God! And the two disciples ... followed Jesus.”
- John 1:38-39. Jesus said, “Come and see.”
- John 1:40-41. Andrew brought Simon Peter to Christ. Jesus found Philip. Philip found Nathanael. †8. Daniel Rona
- What can we do to invite others to “come and see” the Savior?

Next Week: L5 “Born Again”; See L5: [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212](#).) † •

†1. **Background Information:** “Centuries before John’s birth, many prophets foresaw his ministry and testified of his greatness as the one who would prepare the way for the Messiah (Isaiah 40:3; 1 Nephi 10:7–10). In preparation for John’s ministry, the angel Gabriel announced John’s forthcoming birth (Luke 1:13–19), Zacharias prophesied on the day of John’s naming and circumcision (Luke 1:67–79), and an angel ordained eight-day-old John to his mission (D&C 84:27–28). The crowning statement of John’s greatness came from the Savior himself, who said, ‘Among those that are born of women there is not a greater prophet than John the Baptist’ (Luke 7:28).

“John was born about six months before Jesus. Shortly after Jesus’ birth, Herod, feeling threatened by the announcement that a new king of the Jews had been born, “slew all the children that were in Bethlehem, and in all the coasts thereof, from two years old and under” (Matthew 2:16). To protect Jesus, an angel appeared to Joseph in a dream and directed him to take Jesus and Mary to Egypt (Matthew 2:13–15). To protect John, “Zacharias caused [Elisabeth] to take him into the mountains, where he was raised on locusts and wild honey” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [1976], 261). John began his public ministry many years later, first preaching in the wilderness and then in Jerusalem and “all the region round about Jordan” (Matthew 3:5).” (*Lesson Manual*)

†2. **The Jews and Baptism:** “According to some historians, the Jews would baptize their proselytes, but were not baptized themselves (*The Expositor’s Bible Commentary*, Vol. 8, p. 103). With our additional Latter-day revelation, we know that baptism has been a necessary ordinance since the world began—even Adam was baptized (see Moses 6:53)—but perhaps this practice had disappeared with the decline into apostasy [*sic*] that preceded John’s time. The Jews seemed to feel that simply being of the House of Israel made them holy, and they had no need of the ordinance of baptism, or of a Savior. That would explain why Jesus criticized the Pharisees and Saducees [*sic*] who came to his baptism, but did not intend to be baptized themselves. (Nancy Jensen, “[New Testament Lesson #4](#)” (Notice the JST change in verse 7.)

†3. **Holy Ghost:** “We are baptized with the Holy Ghost and with fire when we receive the gift of the Holy Ghost by the laying on of hands (D&C:41). ‘The gift of the Holy Ghost is the right to have, whenever one is worthy, the companionship of the Holy Ghost... It acts as a cleansing agent to purify a person and sanctify him from all sin. Thus it is often spoken of as “fire”’ (Bible Dictionary, “[Holy Ghost](#),” 704). (*Lesson Manual*)

†4. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie:** “No one is ever prepared for the Lord while he remains in his sins. The Lord does not save people in their sins, but from their sins. The plan of salvation is designed to enable men to free themselves from sin so they can, as clean and spotless beings, enter the presence of him who is without sin. No one is ever prepared for the Lord until he confesses and forsakes his sins.” (*The Mortal Messiah*, Book 1, 386–387)

†5. **President David O. McKay:** “Nearly every temptation that comes to you and me comes in one of those forms [that they came to Jesus in]. Classify them, and you will find that under one of those three nearly every given temptation that makes you and me spotted, even so little maybe, comes to us as (1) a temptation of the appetite or passion; (2) a yielding to the pride and fashion or vanity of those alienated from the things of the world, or (3) a desire for the riches of the world, or power among men.” (*Gospel Ideals*, 154)

†6. **Julie Szejnja’s Testimony:** “I made it a point to push everything else aside in my life and truly study the scriptures... These past two weeks it has made an incredible difference.” (I recorded these words from her testimony on Sunday, August 5, 2012.)

†7. **Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin:** “The Lord is well aware of our mortality. He knows our weaknesses. He understands the challenges of our everyday lives. He has great empathy for the temptations of earthly appetites and passions” (“[Faith of Our Fathers](#),” *Ensign*, May 1996, 34).

†8. **Daniel Rona:** “The word Messiah literally means ‘the anointed one.’ Anointing includes the practical and symbolic qualities of softening and healing. ‘Anointing also figured in the coronation of the king, in the ordination of Aaron and his sons as priests, and in the purification of a person suffering from leprosy. These anointings ... symbolized the new rank and power given to the anointed person and they evoked God’s blessing on him.’” (*Encyclopedia Judaica Jr.*, cited in [HIDDEN LDS/JEWISH INSIGHTS for NTL4](#) by Daniel Rona)

Recommended Reading:

1. Frank S. Gonzalez, “[Repentance: A Daily Pattern](#),” *Ensign*, August 1980.
2. Daniel Rona, “[HIDDEN LDS/JEWISH INSIGHTS FOR NTL4](#).”
3. Elder Neal A. Maxwell, “[Apply the Atoning Blood of Christ](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997, 23).
4. Nancy Jensen, “[New Testament Lesson #4](#),” at LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, January 17, 2011.

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